



Storytelling for Career Readiness

Participant Guide

This guide goes with the full workshop and helps you follow along, take notes, and build your stories, brief introductions, and interview answers.

Welcome

What this session is about:

- Learning how to talk about your tech skills
- Building confidence for interviews
- Turning experiences into strong stories

Agenda

Today's flow:

1. Warm-up
2. Storytelling frameworks
3. Group story-building
4. Interview role-plays
5. Your personal story and brief introduction
6. Wrap-up

Notes:

Warm-up: Cloud in a post

Write *one* basic sentence explaining something you've learned in your classes. Write as if you were posting it on social media for someone who knows nothing about the cloud.

Your sentence:

Examples

I learned how the cloud works so your apps don't crash when everyone's online at the same time.

AWS makes it possible for you to build cool stuff without needing a giant server room in your basement.

The cloud is like a streaming service for computer power. You use what you need, when you need it.

Which sentence feels clearest to you? Why?

Notes:

Why streamlining is tough

Have you ever tried to explain something technical and realized people were having trouble understanding what you were saying?

STAR storytelling framework

Use STAR to build every story.

Situation:

Task:

Action:

Result:

Behavioral question

Write a STAR answer for the following: “Tell me about a time you fixed a complex problem.”

STAR draft:

STAR: Cloud in a post 2.0

Expand your warm-up sentence into a full STAR story.

Jargon-heavy IoT explanation

Which tech words do you use that might confuse someone not in tech?

List them here:

Clear business story

Rewrite a technical explanation in basic, impact-focused language.

Notes:

Why it works

Which skill do *you* want to improve most?

(Check one or write your own)

☐ Being clear

- ☐ Explaining the impact
 - ☐ Staying calm when talking
 - ☐ Using basic language
 - ☐ Other:
-

Story-building

Choose a scenario and create your STAR story.

Scenario chosen:

STAR draft:

Notes:

Scenario options – see Appendix A

Choose one:

- ☐ Smart campus
- ☐ Healthcare
- ☐ Agriculture

☐ Logistics

Why did you pick this one?

Group work instructions

Practice your story out loud. Take notes on what worked and what to fix.

What worked:

What to improve:

Notes:

Group work debrief

Which part felt most natural?

Which part felt hardest?

Notes:

Interview role-plays

Your role this round:

☐ Candidate ☐ Interviewer ☐ Observer

Notes:

Your role this round:

☐ Candidate ☐ Interviewer ☐ Observer

Notes:

Your role this round:

☐ Candidate ☐ Interviewer ☐ Observer

Notes:

Technical interview prompts

Pick one and explain it in basic terms:

- How does the device send data?
- How does the cloud process that data?
- What happens after the server receives it?

Your explanation:

Non-technical interview prompts

Pick one:

- How does this save people time or money?
- How does this improve the user experience?
- Why does this matter?

Your answer:

Notes:

Observer checklist

Give clear, helpful feedback:

- Was the story clear?
- Did they follow STAR?
- Any jargon they should clarify?
- What could be stronger?

Notes:

Probing tips for interviewers

Practice asking good follow-up questions.

Your probing questions:

Notes:

30-second brief introduction

Build your 30-second introduction.

Who you are:

What you've done or your experience:

What your skills are:

Your ask (next step):

Notes:

Activity: Pair feedback

Feedback from your partner.

What was clear?

What to refine:

Notes:

Brief introduction checklist

Check your introduction:

- ☐ Clear intro
- ☐ Relevant experience
- ☐ Skills explanation
- ☐ Clear ask

What do you still want to work on?

Avoid over-structuring

Which part of your story or introduction sounds too rehearsed?

Notes:

Wrap-up

One thing you learned today:

One thing you want to practice more:

Thank you

What are your next steps?

Examples: Practice with a friend, record yourself, refine your introduction, apply for a role

Your next step:

Notes:

Appendix A

Scenarios Pack

Welcome! This guide gives you **behavioral interview questions and basic STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result) examples** based on real-world tech scenarios in Smart Campus, Healthcare, Agriculture, and Logistics. It's designed to help you **showcase problem-solving skills, technical know-how, and real impact** in interviews. Each STAR example shows how to tell a clear story: the challenge you faced, what you did, and the results you achieved.

How to use this guide:

- **If you're practicing for interviews:** Use the questions to think about your own experiences and how you'd answer them. The STAR examples give you a template to structure your answers.
- **If you're learning from examples:** See how small technical projects can make a big difference. Notice how actions are tied to real results—it's all about showing what you can do.

This guide helps you **feel confident in interviews** by giving you a clear way to tell your story and highlight your skills.

Smart Campus Scenarios

Scenario 1: Energy Waste Reduction

- Tell me about a time you identified an opportunity to reduce waste or inefficiency. How did you approach it?
- Describe a project where you used automation to solve a recurring problem. What steps did you take?
- How did you measure the impact of your solution? Can you share the results?
- Have you ever implemented a solution that didn't require constant human oversight? How did you ensure it worked reliably?

Sample response

Situation:

Lights were being left on in empty classrooms, wasting energy.

Task:

Find an efficient way to cut energy waste without needing staff to constantly check rooms.

Action:

Installed motion sensors, connected to AWS IoT Core, and created an automation that shuts lights off after rooms are empty.

Result:

Electricity use dropped by 22% in one semester.

Debrief notes:

- Focus on impact (energy saved, cost reduction)
- Great example of automation plus IoT

Scenario 2: Safety Hallway Lighting

- Give an example of a time you improved safety or reliability in a system. What problem were you solving?
- Describe a situation where you implemented a monitoring or alerting system. How did it help?
- How did you prioritize fixes when multiple issues occurred?
- Can you talk about a basic technical solution that had a big impact?

Sample response

Situation:

Students reported dark hallways because lights failed randomly.

Task:

Make the lighting system more reliable and quicker to fix.

Action:

Set up smart bulbs with real-time monitoring with alerts sent instantly through Amazon SNS when a bulb failed.

Result:

Fix time dropped from *days to hours*, improving campus safety.

Debrief notes:

- Safety plus reliability wins
- Basic IoT plus alerting story

Healthcare Scenarios

Scenario 1: Wearable Vitals Dropping Offline

- Tell me about a time you solved a mission-critical connectivity or reliability issue.
- How did you troubleshoot intermittent failures in a system? Which steps worked best?
- Describe a situation where you improved uptime or data accuracy. How did you measure success?
- Have you ever designed a backup or failover solution? Which approach did you take?

Sample response

Situation:

Hospital wearable devices (heart rate, temp, and more) kept disconnecting.

Task:

Keep devices online so nurses don't miss important health data.

Action:

Added LTE backup when Wi-Fi dropped, added retry logic, which resulted in stabilized data flow into AWS IoT.

Result:

Device uptime increased to 98%, fewer missed alerts.

Debrief notes:

- Mission-critical data
- Efficient way to show reliability plus troubleshooting

Scenario 2: Medication Refrigerator Monitoring

- Give an example of when you automated a manual process. What was the outcome?
- Tell me about a project where you ensured compliance or safety through monitoring.
- How did you handle alerts or exceptions in your system?
- Describe how your solution created measurable impact for your team or organization.

Sample response

Situation:

Staff manually checked medicine refrigerator temperatures every few hours—super slow and easy to miss.

Task:

Make temperature tracking automatic and accurate every day.

Action:

Added IoT thermometers, wrote AWS Lambda function, stored temperature data in Amazon DynamoDB, and created alerts.

Result:

Zero medication spoilage events that quarter.

Debrief notes:

- Great for showing automation plus cost savings
- Clear before and after impact

Agriculture Scenarios

Scenario 1: Uneven Soil Moisture

- Tell me about a time you helped improve operational efficiency using data.
- How have you used sensors or monitoring systems to inform decision-making?
- Describe a project where you translated technical data into actionable insights for non-technical users.
- Can you give an example of a solution that directly increased output or performance?

Sample response

Situation:

Farmers noticed some areas of a field weren't growing as well due to inconsistent watering.

Task:

Help identify dry spots quickly.

Action:

Placed soil moisture sensors and added data to a dashboard so farmers could adjust irrigation schedules.

Result:

Crop yield improved by 15%.

Debrief notes:

- Strong IoT fundamentals
- Not difficult to visualize

Scenario 2: Weather-Aware Irrigation

- Give an example of using external data (like weather or market data) to optimize processes.
- How have you automated a system to save resources or costs?
- Describe a time when your solution had a positive environmental or sustainability impact.
- Which steps did you take to ensure your automation worked reliably under changing conditions?

Sample response

Situation:

Farmers were wasting water because the irrigation system turned on, even when the weather forecast predicted rain.

Task:

Prevent unnecessary watering.

Action:

Connected weather API, created rules to skip irrigation on rainy days, and automated scheduling.

Result:

Saved *1.2 million liters of water* in one season.

Debrief notes:

- Great environmental impact story
- Shows automation plus cost and environment savings

Logistics Scenarios

Scenario 1: Lost or Misplaced Packages

- Tell me about a time you solved a tracking or inventory problem. How did you approach it?
- Describe a situation where technology helped reduce errors in a workflow.
- How did you ensure stakeholders could effortlessly understand and use your solution?
- Can you share the measurable impact of your solution?

Sample response

Situation:

Packages kept getting lost in the warehouse because tracking was manual.

Task:

Help locate items faster and reduce missing shipments.

Action:

Added RFID tags and real-time tracking, and built a location dashboard.

Result:

Lost packages dropped by 95%.

Debrief notes:

- Great for problem-solving
- Uncomplicated to explain to non-tech people

Scenario 2: Inefficient Delivery Routes

- Give an example of optimizing a process using data or automation.
- Tell me about a time you integrated multiple systems to improve operational efficiency.
- How did you measure the cost or time savings of your solution?
- Describe a project where your solution had a direct business impact.

Sample response

Situation:

Delivery drivers were taking long or inefficient routes.

Task:

Help optimize delivery paths.

Action:

Used a route optimization API, integrated with GPS, and automated best-route suggestions.

Result:

Saved 17% on fuel costs and sped up deliveries.

Debrief notes:

- Strong business value
- Shows cloud plus automation plus data